

All living things

Every living thing contains carbon. Human beings take in carbon through carbohydrates, fats, and proteins in food, and release it as carbon dioxide gas when breathing out. It is also released from dead matter, sometimes quite soon, sometimes millions of years later in fuels like oil and coal.

Carbon cycle

Green plants take in the gas carbon dioxide from the air and use it to make food, converting it into things such as carbohydrates. Animals take in some of the carbon when they eat plants.

Animals

Animals such as these sheep contribute to the carbon cycle by eating, breathing, and dropping waste. They take in carbon in the plants they eat, and release it when they breathe out. Their bodies will release more carbon when they die.

Carbon dioxide in the atmosphere

CARBON DIOXIDE

OXYGEN

Animals breathe out carbon dioxide.

Animals eat plants and take in some carbon.

CARBON

CARBON DIOXIDE RELEASED

An animal's droppings also contribute to the carbon cycle.